OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Shoalhaven's Deputy Mayor vote: Cr Norris asked to explain backing Clancy over Tribe

Sent 30 September 2026 · To Cr Norris, Cr Tribe, Cr Clancy, Cr Casmiri · Response requested by 7 October 2026

EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL
Open letter

30 September 2026
Cr Matthew Norris
Shoalhaven City Council, Ward 1
By email: matthew.norris@shoalhaven.nsw.gov.au

Dear Cr Norris,
Your vote for Deputy Mayor on 22 September 2026: a request to explain it

I am asking you to explain, in public, why you voted for Cr Selena Clancy rather than Cr Jemma Tribe as Deputy Mayor, what you weighed in the two of them, and what decided it for you.
It is a question, not an allegation, and it is one any ratepayer is entitled to put to a councillor about a public vote.
What the record shows
On 22 September, the motion to keep Cr Peter Wilkins as Deputy Mayor failed, 4 votes to 9, and Cr Wilkins withdrew. The contest that followed was Cr Clancy against Cr Tribe. As I have recorded it, the vote went this way:
Candidate
Councillors recorded as voting for
Cr Selena Clancy (7)
White, Dunn, Casmiri, Steele, Kemp, Clancy and Norris
Cr Jemma Tribe (6)
Wilkins, Proudfoot, Tribe, Krikstolaitis, Boyd and Killian

Your vote was the seventh. Without it the count is 6–6. Then, once Cr Clancy was elected, Cr Casmiri withdrew his own nomination for Assistant Deputy Mayor, and you were elected to that role unopposed.
I have not seen you explain any of this.
Why the sequence raises a question
I do not know why you voted as you did, and I am not saying there was an arrangement of any kind.
But you should know how the sequence reads from the public gallery: Cr Casmiri stood aside, Cr Clancy won by one vote, and you ended up holding a leadership title. Right or

wrong, many residents have concluded that one thing was traded for another.
Some long-standing Labor supporters have told me they are unhappy and cannot see why a Labor councillor would want to be close to the leadership of the group that has just come apart.
Only you can settle that.
If there was no understanding, express or implied, one plain sentence from you says so and the perception loses its fuel.
If there was a different reason, a good one, the community is entitled to hear it. Silence lets the worst reading stand, and it is the only reading on the public record.
The merits of the two candidates
The public has very little to go on. Council's own web pages for both councillors have an empty "History with Council" section and no biography.
Residents know that Cr Clancy has held the Assistant Deputy Mayor role during the current term, that she represents Ward 1 as you do, and that Cr Tribe is an Independent for Ward 2. Beyond that, all we have is how each of you voted.
The Deputy Mayor can be called on to exercise the Mayor's functions when the Mayor is absent, as section 231 of the Local Government Act 1993 provides. That is not a ceremonial matter, given the Mayor's recent extended leave.
So please say, in your own words, how you assessed each of them on the things that matter for that job: chairing a divided chamber fairly, readiness to step into the Mayor's role, independence from any bloc, respect for meeting procedure, time available, and the confidence the community can place in them.
The 2024 mayoral vote was not a formality.

Cr Jemma Tribe won 23,648 first-preference votes across the whole city, 35.79 per cent, and 44.73 per cent of the two-candidate count against Mayor White.

No other sitting councillor asked every voter in Shoalhaven for the top job. With the Mayor on extended leave from the office, the Deputy Mayor's role of standing in for her became more than ceremonial. It was fair to ask whose voice the community had asked to be heard at the top table.

Cr Clancy came into the chamber on Team Tribe's ticket. On the published figures, that ticket polled 20.40 per cent in Ward 1, just over the 20 per cent needed for one seat in a four-member ward.

That suggests her seat rested on support for Cr Tribe's team.

Cr Clancy told me herself, around the time of the first meeting of this term, that she and Cr Tribe had parted company. The recorded votes bear that out.

Across the contested divisions from October 2024 to April 2026, the two voted the same way only 13 per cent of the time,

while Cr Clancy voted with Mayor White 95 per cent of the time.

Every councillor is entitled to vote as she sees fit. But voters who backed Team Tribe were choosing a team.

In Labor's language, a member who is elected on a team's votes and then votes with the other side is called a rat.

Cr Tribe's ticket is not the Labor Party, and I am not suggesting Cr Clancy broke any pledge, but the comparison shows why many residents feel let down.

Choosing a councillor who has voted with the other bloc on nearly every contested question, over the leader of the ticket she was elected on, left the 44.7 per cent with no voice in either top job. Residents are entitled to have that explained, and I ask Cr Norris whether that record was part of his thinking.

Why asking for an explanation is a democratic act

Section 232(1) of the Act describes the role of a councillor as, among other things, to represent the collective interests of residents, ratepayers and the local community, and to facilitate communication between the local community and the governing body. Section 232(2) adds that a councillor is accountable to the local community for the performance of the council. A vote on who leads the council is part of that performance. Explaining it afterwards is part of the job, not an imposition on it.

Some have described the questions being asked as a mob. They are a courteous request, in writing and on the record, that a councillor explain a public vote, and I have not called anybody a name. Nobody is asking you to vote differently next time. Democracy depends on votes being cast openly and then defended openly. A vote that is never explained leaves the public guessing, and guessing is where suspicion grows.

I also do not accept that the question depends on party labels. Residents do not need a Labor candidate in the contest to ask why a Labor councillor backed one independent over another, and they do not need a party card to ask why the vote landed where it did. Two of your Labor colleagues, Cr Krikstolaitis and Cr Boyd, voted the other way, as did the Greens councillor.

My questions

1. Why did you vote for Cr Clancy over Cr Tribe? How did you assess each against the role?
2. What was the single deciding factor for you?
3. Before the meeting on 22 September, did you discuss the Deputy Mayor vote, or the Assistant Deputy Mayor position, with Cr Casmiri, Cr Clancy or any other councillor?
4. Was there any understanding, arrangement or expectation, express or implied, connecting Cr Casmiri's withdrawal, your election as Assistant Deputy Mayor and your vote for Cr Clancy? If not, will you say so plainly?
5. When did you decide to accept the Assistant Deputy Mayor nomination, and was that before or after you cast your vote for Deputy Mayor?

6. What are the duties, authority and any allowance or resources attached to the Assistant Deputy Mayor role, and where is it established? I cannot find it in the Local Government Act.

7. Did you consult your Labor colleagues, or anyone in the Labor Party, before voting? If your vote differed from their advice or from your colleagues' votes, why?

What happens next

I will publish whatever response I receive, including none. Please reply by 5pm on Wednesday 7 October 2026. A few sentences would do.

For transparency, I am copying this letter to the community groups, Accredited Community Forums, members of parliament, union, party office and local journalists on my Community mailing list. I do this so that everyone with an interest in how our Council works is looking at the same information at the same time.

Each of them is free to follow up in whatever way they think appropriate.

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero
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